the shares of Tata Sons. How would you deflect the charge that you were doing things for yourself? How would you erect a Chinese wall?'

His answer, though not direct, sought to allay any apprehensions the committee may have had: 'I have in the past even closed a business to my detriment so that I was not seen to be benefiting myself,' Mistry replied.

The second question was: 'Therefore a sacrifice would have to be made, and Mr CM [Cyrus Mistry] would have to divest himself of any executive position in his company.'

Mistry replied: 'I would hold no executive position but remain on the board of the holding company.'

The third question was: 'But if this is not possible, as one must not only be clean but be seen to be clean … Would Mr CM be willing to put his holdings in escrow during the time he was Chairman Tata Sons?'

To this, Mistry said: 'I have not explored that option yet. However, I would opt out of any situation where there was any conflict of interest.'

The committee took the replies to mean that Mistry would do what was required to avoid any conflict of interest between the Shapoorji Pallonji Group and the Tatas. This was recorded at the end of the minutes of the meeting, which read: 'He [Mistry] had not addressed the question of putting his holdings in his firm in escrow should he be appointed to this position. This he had said he would think about, though he would distance himself should there be a conflict of interest.'

The issue of conflict of interest came up for specific reference in the important selection committee meeting on 17 October 2011. The committee once again underscored that Mistry 'would have to distance himself from his existing business interests. This will be crucial, both for him and his perception in the public domain'. Mistry's reply was reassuring. His advisors had informed him that the concept of a blind trust is absent in India. Nevertheless, Mistry said that 'he was aware that distancing himself from his company's holding in TSL was essential'.

The committee's conclusion was also communicated to Ratan in a letter signed by all its members. The letter said, 'On his appointment, it has been agreed that Mr Cyrus Mistry will fully disassociate himself from his family business in a legal manner to the satisfaction of the group.' The minutes of the meeting and the letter evidently satisfied Ratan.

Ratan Rebuffed